

If Each AI Search Causes That Much Environmental Damage... How Are We Not Out of Resources Yet?

Posted by u/BritKein • 0 points • 18 comments

I keep seeing these studies and articles discussing the massive negative impact environmentally that even a single AI search does. It's even become a hot enough topic that you are considered a bad person for using AI to some people for that reason.

I hadn't taken it too seriously when it was first mentioned because experts were more concerned with just limiting the damage AI does by altering AI systems rather than getting rid of it all together, so I assumed it wasn't a big deal. But after seeing the articles, comparisons, and other people's opinions on the matter, shouldn't we already be like...out of resources? There are billions of people using AI now, and that's billions and billions of searches so I don't understand how everything is still fine?

Comments

u/Inevitable-Regret411 • 3 points • 2025-02-11 18:28 UTC

Think about it this way. Imagine you've got a million pounds in your bank account, and your rent every month is £600. One day you move to a new place where the rent is £6000 a month. You're not going to run out of money straight away, and probably not anytime soon, but you are burning through it at a much higher rate.

u/aRabidGerbil • 2 points • 2025-02-11 17:00 UTC

Most of the damage is in energy consumption and potable water being used for cooling. So most of the damage isn't that we're using up rare resources, it's that we're making climate change worse and over stretching our water supply.

u/allabs5 • 1 points • 2025-02-11 16:55 UTC

I remember similar articles for search engines back in the days quoting how much power was needed for a Google search. It is true that AI is consuming a lot of resources at the moment, however AI hardware will get better and will require less energy. The AI software will also become more optimized and use less energy. In the long run we will have much more powerful systems requiring less energy. Also have in mind that AI can be used to solve hard problems that can save time of scientists and engineers. Although it requires a lot of power, it might save months or years of research.

On other hand I guess we are shifting the focus from cars and other areas that require a lot of power. The reason we have not run out of power for AI is that we have a lot of available power.

I remember similar discussions for electric cars and how they will crash the grid. Well, 10 years later the grid is actually better with electric cars.

You can watch Nvidia CEO talking about the latest generation of server chips that require 100x less energy than the ones from 8 years ago.

u/BritKein • 1 points • 2025-02-11 17:04 UTC

That was kind of my initial thoughts and why I hadn't been concerning myself much about it. I remember this happening with pretty much every major technological advancement and I'm only 21 lol. But then I made a post that mentioned I used AI and the comments were livid with me.

u/itsnotcomplicated1 • 1 points • 2025-02-11 16:55 UTC

That's how I feel when they say it takes 1 gallon of water to grow one almond.

u/ProperAd95 • 3 points • 2025-02-11 17:04 UTC

That stat is true, they're just forgetting to tell you that producing cow's milk requires way more water.

u/ProperAd95 • 3 points • 2025-02-11 16:44 UTC

>There are billions of people using AI now

There aren't.

u/BritKein • 1 points • 2025-02-11 16:45 UTC

Fixed it :)

u/ProperAd95 • 3 points • 2025-02-11 16:50 UTC

I mean, I wasn't asking you to fix it, that mistake is the answer to your question. Demand isn't high enough for the negative impacts to be noticeable to you. It's not like using AI forces someone to cut down a tree or something. It just requires a lot of electricity, and the way we generate electricity is largely bad for the environment. We've been doing a good job of using less electricity but those trends have all stopped because of increase demands from AI processing. It's

just a new problem we have to deal with long-term, in no universe was it ever going to exhaust the Earth of resources within one year.

u/BritKein • 1 points • 2025-02-11 17:16 UTC

I still don't understand how Millions could be constantly using AI and for us to not be having obvious issues, especially with stats floating about with such high estimations of power usage.

u/ProperAd95 • 0 points • 2025-02-11 17:36 UTC

You're struggling to understand only because you came into this conversation with a bunch of unfounded assumptions. Drop those assumptions and simply read what I am saying to you.

u/BritKein • 1 points • 2025-02-11 17:45 UTC

Stats show at least a quarter of Americans are using AI constantly or several times a day. That is several millions, and that is only in one country.

[<https://www.pewresearch.org/science/2023/02/15/public-awareness-of-artificial-intelligence-in-everyday-activities/>]
(<https://www.pewresearch.org/science/2023/02/15/public-awareness-of-artificial-intelligence-in-everyday-activities/>)

I understand what you are trying to convey, however, stating that I came into this with unfounded assumptions is incorrect.

u/ProperAd95 • 1 points • 2025-02-11 17:48 UTC

You are the worst kind of person. Don't come here asking questions if you're just going to argue with objectively correct answers. If you're so sure you've got it all figured out, delete this thread. Otherwise, shut the fuck up, listen, and learn.

Your source is a self-reported survey, it has nothing whatsoever to do with the amount people are actually using AI. It's literally just people saying they THINK they INTERACT with AI that much. It's not a direct measure of how much people are using it.

u/BritKein • 1 points • 2025-02-11 17:51 UTC

You have got to calm down, I asked a question, you're answer did not fully answer it and just led me to more questions. If you don't wish to answer said question, then don't.

Genuinely, if you the worst kind of person to you is someone further inquiring and asking you further questions on your answer, I'm glad you

are living a well and sheltered life lol.

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